Chapter review 1 of 25

Posture & Hand Shape

Everything in chapter 1, in one pack: the app lesson (as the Lesson Book), the Workbook, the Teacher copy, the online drill, and a first draft of the new public page for Google. Prepared 8 October 2026.

What's inside

What I found: mistakes to fix (A) and questions for you (B)	pages 2-3
The online drill: the three levels and every answer line	page 4
Lesson Book, chapter 1 (the same steps as the app)	pages 5-12
Workbook, chapter 1	pages 13-19
Teacher copy, chapter 1	pages 20-21
Draft public page for Google (yellow = your words go here)	pages 22-27

How to check

1. Read pages 2 and 3 first: what I already found. Tick **Fix** or **Leave it**, and answer the yellow questions.
2. Go through the rest with a red pen. Mark anything wrong, unclear, or not how you teach it.
3. Send photos of the marked pages, or just tell me in the chat. Either is fine.

Three questions for the public page

Your answers become your own words on the page. Two or three sentences each is plenty.

1. What do students get wrong most in this chapter?

2. What do you say or do that works? A phrase, a trick, a game.

3. What must not be missing?

A. Mistakes I found

I will fix these once you tick Fix. Leave it means keep it as it is.

A1 **Online drill, level 3 "Which finger?"** Every finger has its number drawn on it, so the answer is showing (see page 4 of this pack). The "Show me finger 3!" game in lesson step 6 has the same problem.

Fix: Hide the numbers while a question is asked; show them after the answer.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A2 **Workbook page 2, the map.** Step 7 says "in the app only", but Workbook page 6 is the posture checklist for step 7. Step 5 (Meet your fingers) is listed as "Left hand, right hand".

Fix: Step 5: Meet your fingers, page 4. Step 7: Posture check, page 6.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A3 **Lesson Book page 2.** The stool picture prints in the "too low" position with a red cross, under "move the stool until every check is green". On paper nobody can move it.

Fix: Print the good set-up, every check green.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A4 **Lesson Book page 3.** It says "six short exercises", but only one (Arm glide) is printed.

Fix: List all six, one line each (as on the website draft).

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A5 **Stool or chair?** The Lesson Book and app say "stool"; the REMEMBER lines (Lesson Book pages 2 and 8) and Workbook pages 2, 3, 6 and 7 say "chair".

Fix: Use "stool" everywhere.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A6 **Finger 4 is explained two ways.** Lesson Book page 6: "tendons tie finger 4 to both 3 and 5". Page 7: "fingers 3 and 4 share a tendon".

Fix: One sentence in both places: "Finger 4 is tied to its neighbours by small bands between the tendons, so it is hard to lift on its own."

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A7 **"Nail joint" or "tip joint"?** The drill and the hand-shape tool say "nail joint caving in"; the checklist says "tip joint firm".

Fix: Use "tip joint" everywhere.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A8 **Knuckle bridge.** The exercise says "press one key slowly and hold for 3", but the fix for collapsed knuckles says "tap each finger".

Fix: Match the exercise: press and hold.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A9 **Teacher copy page 2.** Check-up answers are numbered A1-4, B1-4..., but the Workbook check-up numbers them 1 to 20.

Fix: Use the Workbook numbers.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A10 **The "Wrist too high" drawing** (app, step 4) cuts off the word "wrist" at the top.

Fix: Make the picture a little taller.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

A11 **Korean words (한국어 mode).** knuckle: 너클 / 마디 / 손가락 마디. forearm: 팔뚝 / 아래팔. tip joint: 손톱 마디 / 손끝 관절.

Fix: One word each: 마디, 아래팔, 손끝 관절.

☐ Fix ☐ Leave it

B. Please decide

Teaching questions only you can answer. A word or two on the line is enough.

B1 **"3 & 2 - the strongest and most agile"** (Lesson Book page 6). The thumb is usually called the strongest finger; 2 and 3 are the most independent. Change to "2 & 3 - the most independent and agile"?

B2 **Leaning forward.** The checklist says "back tall, leaning slightly forward" is right, but the Teacher copy page 1 lists "leaning forward" as a fault (sitting too far). How far forward is right for you?

B3 **Elbows or forearm?** Workbook pages 3 and 6 tick "elbows level with the keys"; everywhere else says "forearm level with the keys". The same thing for you, or should the elbow be a little above the keys?

B4 **Wrist height.** "A little above the keys, level with the forearm, nearly as high as the knuckles." Is that how you teach it?

B5 **Finger nicknames:** Captain Thumb, Pointer, Tall Middle, Shy Ring, Baby Pinky. Keep them, or the names you use?

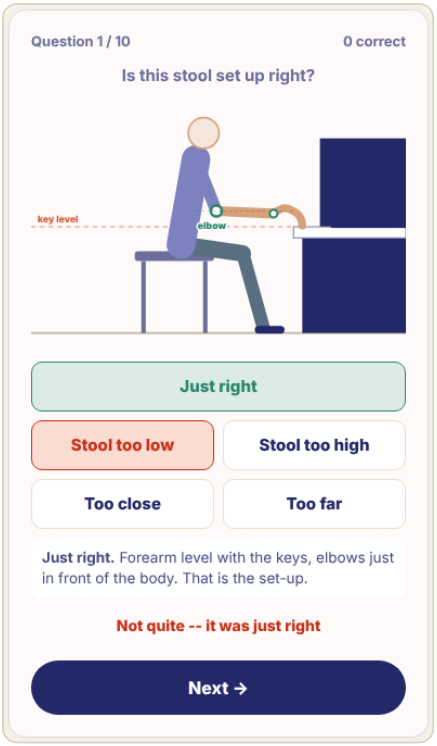
B6 **Workbook page 6, Spot the difference.** Can a child see all 5 mistakes? Flat fingers are very small in the picture.

B7 **Lesson step 3, Feel the arm weight** (gravity, the chain from shoulder to fingertip). Right for the very first chapter, or too much?

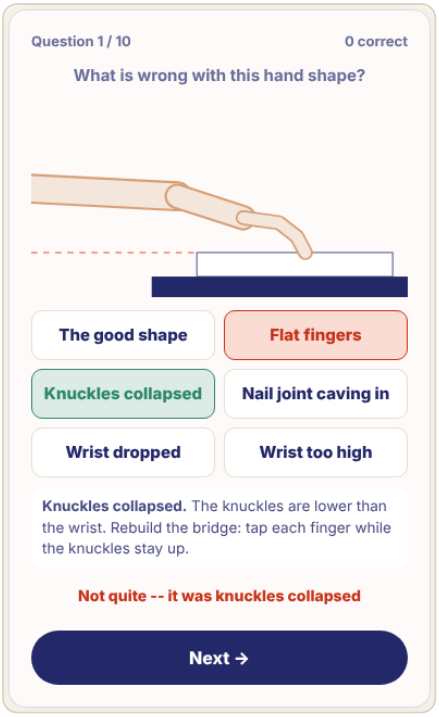
B8 **Your name on the public page.** May it say "Written by Sohyun, a piano teacher in Sydney"? Another name, or no name?

The online drill

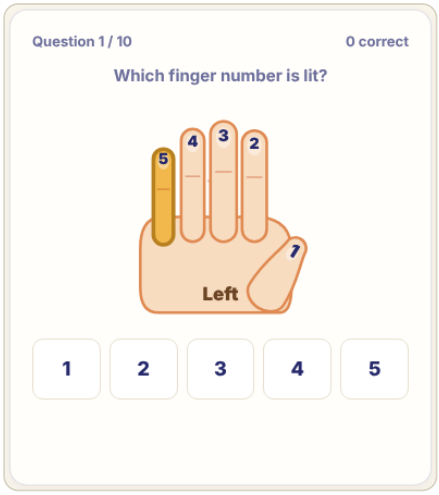
Three levels, 10 questions each. After each answer the child sees one line of explanation. Every explanation is below.



Level 1 · Is the stool set up right?



Level 2 · Spot the hand-shape fault



Level 3 · Which finger? The numbers give the answer away (A1)

Level 1 · Just right. Forearm level with the keys, elbows just in front of the body. That is the set-up.

Level 1 · Stool too low. The forearm slopes up to the keys and the shoulders hunch. Raise the stool.

Level 1 · Stool too high. The forearm slopes down onto the keys. Lower the stool until the forearm is level.

Level 1 · Too close. The elbows are tucked behind the body and the arms are cramped. Slide the stool back a little.

Level 1 · Too far. The arms reach out ahead of the body. Slide the stool closer.

Level 2 · The good shape. Knuckles make a bridge, the wrist is level with the forearm, and the finger plays on its tip.

Level 2 · Flat fingers. The finger lies flat. Hold a small ball, then keep that round shape on the keys.

Level 2 · Knuckles collapsed. The knuckles are lower than the wrist. Rebuild the bridge: tap each finger while the knuckles stay up.

Level 2 · Nail joint caving in. The last joint bends backwards. Play slowly on the tip and keep it firm like a little pillar.

Level 2 · Wrist dropped. The wrist sinks below the keys. Float it up, level with the forearm, like a balloon.

Level 2 · Wrist too high. The wrist is hunched up. Let it sink until elbow, wrist and knuckle make a straight line.

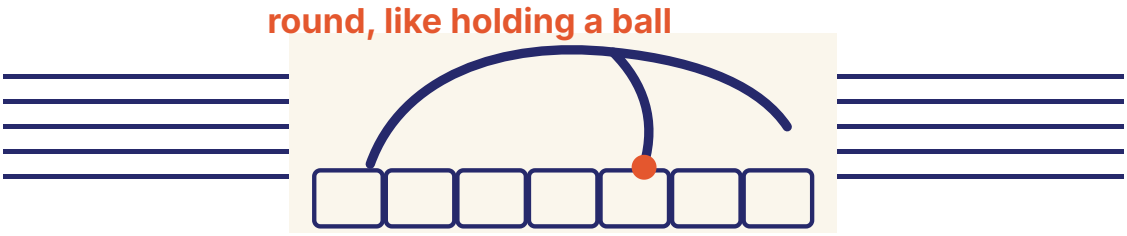
Level 3. A left or right hand with one finger lit; the child taps 1 to 5.

CHAPTER 1

Try it in the app

Posture and hand shape

Before any notes: how to sit, and how the hand is shaped. Get this right first -- everything else builds on it.



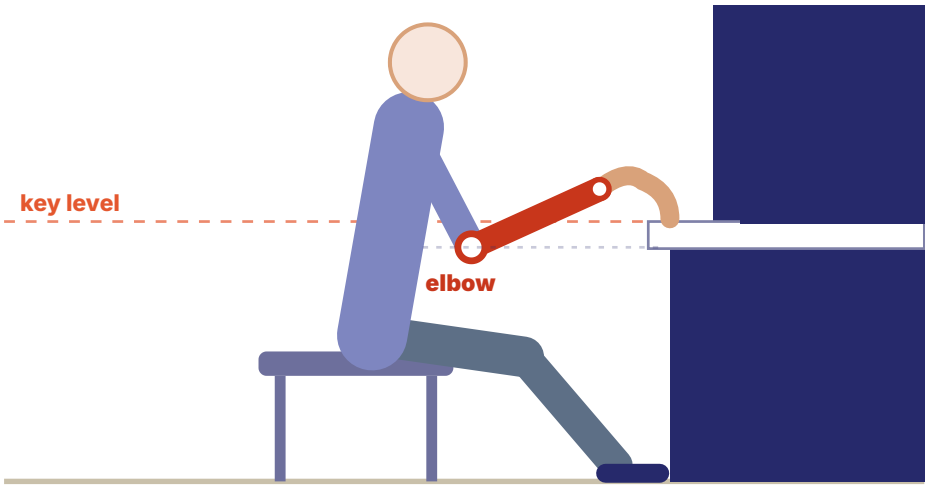
1 Sit at the piano

Sitting

Sit on the front half of the stool, feet flat, facing middle C. Stool height: forearm level with the keys. Distance: elbows just in front of the body, open a little to the side.

Set up the stool

Move the stool until every check is green. The height sets the **forearm** (level with the keys); the distance sets the **elbows** (just in front of the body).



Height **Distance**

- ✔ **Feet flat on the floor**
- ✖ **Forearm level with the keys** -- Elbows are below the keys, so the hands reach up -- raise the stool.
- ✔ **Elbows just in front of the body**
- ✔ **Arms soft, not stretched**

REMEMBER **Sit on the front half of the chair, feet flat, back tall.**

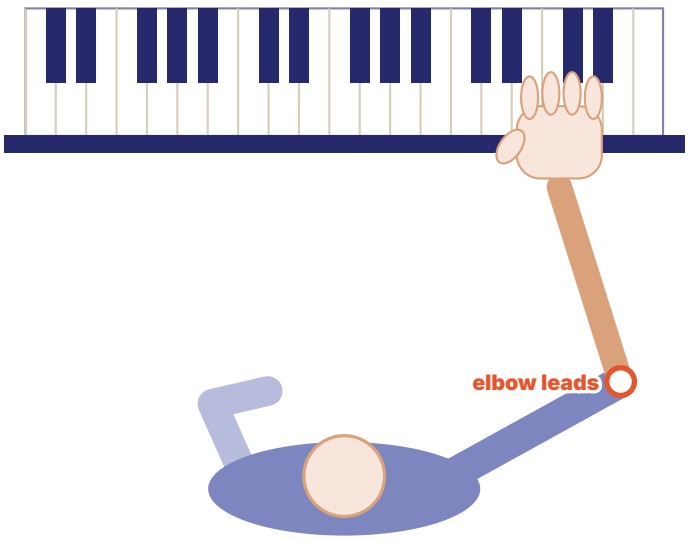
2 Move with the whole arm

The arm carries the hand

Fingers play the keys, but the arm takes the hand where it needs to go -- the hand keeps its shape all the way. Do these a few minutes at the start of every practice.

Move with the whole arm

The hand holds its shape; the **arm** moves it. Six short exercises -- watch the picture, do it, then add a tally mark each time.



sitting back -- room for the arm to travel

1. Put the hand shape on middle C.
2. Carry it up to the next C, and the next -- don't let the fingers walk, let the arm carry them.
3. Come back down. The elbow moves first and opens out.

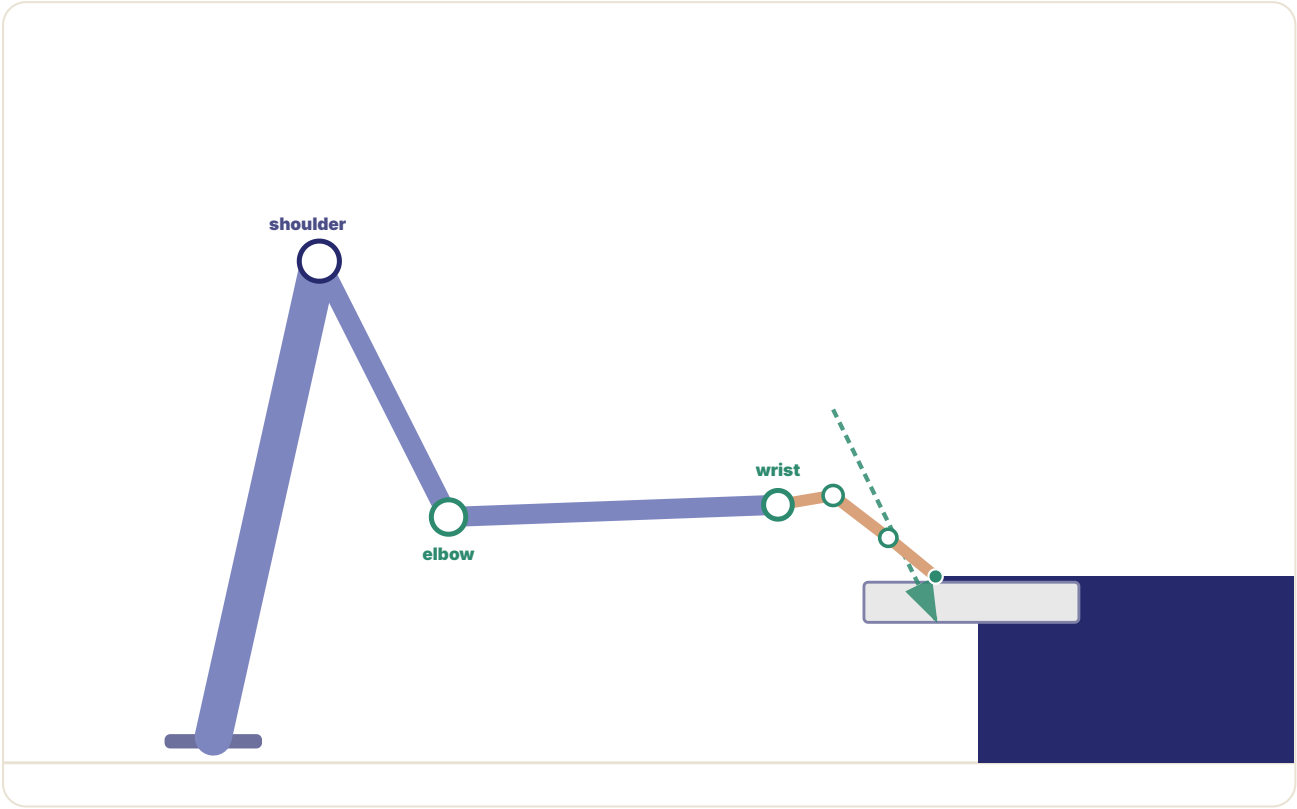
Watch for: The hand looks exactly the same at every C.

REMEMBER **Move from the whole arm -- shoulder, elbow, wrist -- not just the fingers.**

3 Feel the arm weight

Arm weight & alignment

Study the diagram: wrist height and sitting distance both change the picture. Watch the elbow, wrist and finger joints react.



Good alignment

- **ELBOW**
  Floating freely away from the torso -- gravity can do its work.
- **WRIST**
  Neutral and supple -- a flexible shock absorber.
- **FINGERS**
  A strong, curved bridge -- the knuckles carry the arm weight.

This is what "arm weight" really means: a relaxed, aligned chain from shoulder to fingertip lets gravity make the tone -- tension anywhere along the chain blocks it.

REMEMBER **Let the arm feel heavy, then let that weight rest on the keys.**

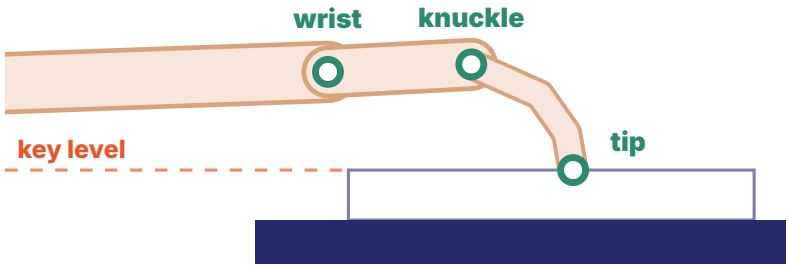
4 The hand shape

A round hand

Let your arms hang, then lift your hands as if holding a small ball. Knuckles up like a bridge, wrist level with the forearm, play on the fingertip pads, the thumb on its side.

The hand shape, from the side

Three check points: **knuckles** up (a bridge), **wrist** level with the forearm, fingers curved onto the **tip**. Spot the fault, then fix it to reach the "Good shape".



✓ The good shape

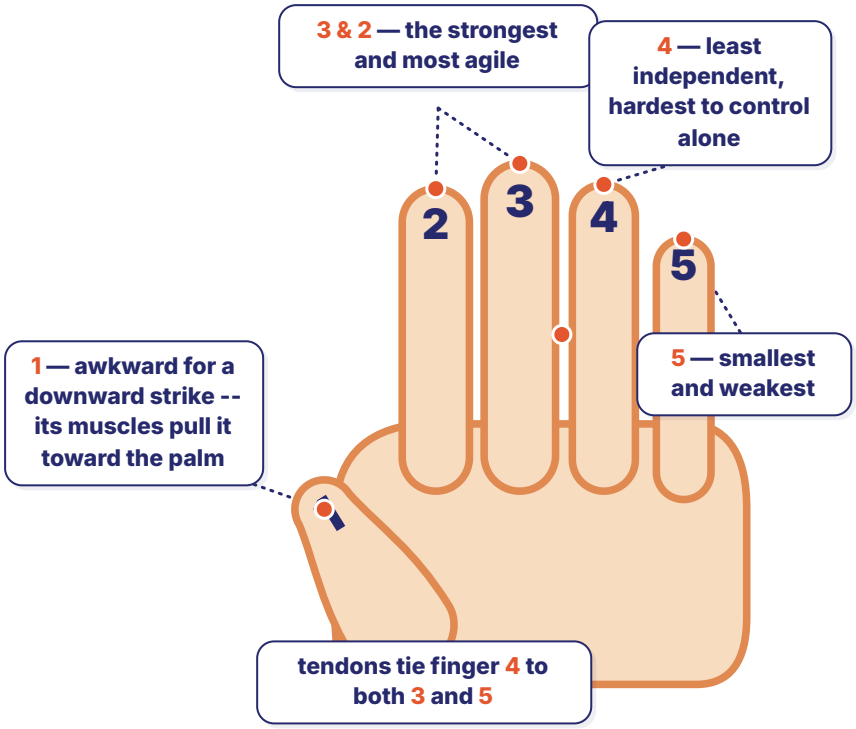
Knuckles make a bridge (the highest point), fingers curve down, you play on the fingertip pad. The wrist sits a little above the keys, level with the forearm -- nearly as high as the knuckles.

REMEMBER **Round fingers, like holding a ball. Play on the tips.**

5 Meet your fingers

Meet your fingers

Every hand is a little different, but these patterns show up in almost everyone -- they're not something you did wrong.



REMEMBER **Every finger is a friend -- even finger 4 and 5 get a turn.**

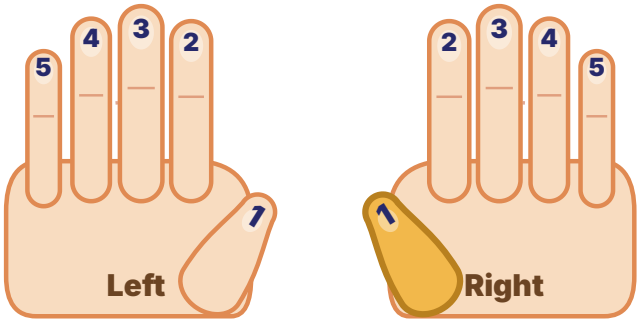
6 Finger numbers

Numbers, thumb to little finger

Every finger has a number, 1 to 5 from the thumb, the same on both hands. Teachers use these constantly -- "put finger 2 on D" -- so they need to be automatic before reading fingerings on the page.

Finger numbers

Both thumbs are **1**, both little fingers are **5**. Hold your hands up like this, wiggle each finger as you say its number -- then play the game.

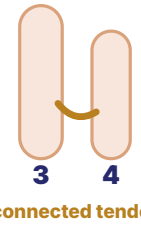


Right hand, finger 1

Captain Thumb

1 Captain Thumb | **2** Pointer | **3** Tall Middle | **4** Shy Ring | **5** Baby Pinky

Why is finger 4 the tricky one?



Fingers 3 and 4 share a tendon under the skin, so lifting finger 4 alone naturally tugs on finger 3 too. That's not a mistake in your hand -- everyone's hands work this way! It just needs a little extra patient practice.

REMEMBER **Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on both hands.**

7 Posture check

Posture check

A check-up for the set-up and the hand, done the same way every time so you can see it improve.

▶ **How to use it**

SITTING

- [ ] Stool height: forearm level with the keys
- [ ] Distance: elbows just in front of the body
- [ ] Sitting on the front half of the stool
- [ ] Feet flat (or on a footstool)
- [ ] Back tall, leaning slightly forward
- [ ] Shoulders down and loose

ARMS

- [ ] Elbows open -- a fist's width from the body
- [ ] Forearm level, not sloping up or down
- [ ] Wrist level with the forearm (not dropped, not hunched)

HANDS

- [ ] Knuckles up -- a bridge
- [ ] Fingers curved (holding a ball)
- [ ] Playing on the fingertip pads
- [ ] Tip joint firm, not caving in
- [ ] Thumb plays on its side corner

MOVING

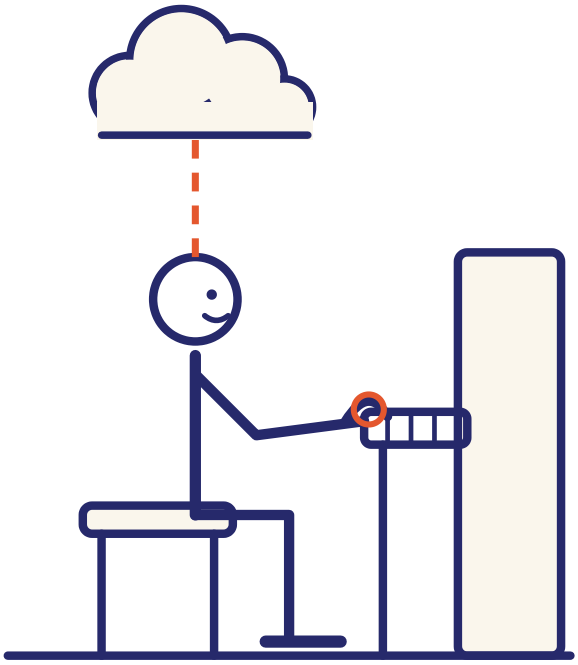
- [ ] The arm carries the hand along the keys
- [ ] The hand keeps its shape while moving
- [ ] No tension -- the arm could wobble freely

REMEMBER **Check your posture before every practice: chair, feet, back, elbows, hands.**

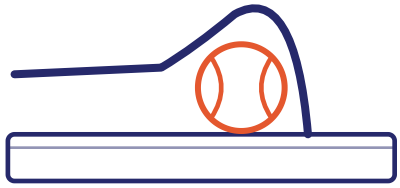
CHAPTER 1

Posture & Hand Shape

How you sit and how you hold your hands makes every note easier -- and keeps your body happy. Each page goes with one step of the Lesson Book chapter.



Sit tall, like a puppet on a string.



Round fingers, like holding a ball.

In this chapter

- [ ] Sitting at the piano — page 3
- [ ] Arm weight — page 3
- [ ] Hand shape — page 4
- [ ] Left hand, right hand — page 4
- [ ] Finger numbers — page 4

Tick a box when you can do it without help.

Scan to open this chapter in the app

★ **Start with the map on the next page.** It shows which page goes with which lesson step, the piano missions, and the online drill. Scan the code above to open the lesson in the app.

Your map for this chapter

One lesson step at a time: read it, do its page, try it online. Tick each step when the page is done.

1 · LESSON BOOK
Read one step with your teacher.

→

2 · WORKBOOK
Do that step's page: TOGETHER, AT HOME, PLAY.

→

3 · APP
Scan the page's code: try the step, then play the drill.

→

4 · CHECK-UP
Page 7, in the lesson, when every step is done.

Lesson step	Workbook page	What it covers	Done
Step 1	page 3	Sitting at the piano	☐
Step 2	page 3	Arm weight	☐
Step 3	page 3	Arm weight	☐
Step 4	page 4	Hand shape	☐
Step 5	page 4	Left hand, right hand · Finger numbers	☐
Step 6	page 4	Left hand, right hand · Finger numbers	☐
Step 7	in the app only		☐

ONLINE

The drill

Scan, then pick a level. Aim for 9 out of 10.

1. Is the stool set up right? best ___/10
2. Spot the hand-shape fault best ___/10
3. Which finger? best ___/10

At the piano

Real-piano missions for this chapter. Tick one box each time you do it with your teacher or at home.

1	Before you play: front of the chair, feet flat, sit tall. Check it in a mirror.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Arm weight: let your arm hang heavy at your side, then lift it and rest it on the keys.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Make a round hand on your knee (like holding a ball), then move it to the keys.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Practise online: scan the code and play the finger-number drill.	☐	☐	☐	☐

The whole path

the same order as the app and the Lesson Book

1	**Getting started**	**Posture & Hand Shape** · Black Keys & Your First Song · Note Names
2	**Reading notes**	Reading the Staff · Ledger Lines · Tones & Semitones
3	**Rhythm**	Pulse & Counting · Notes & Rests · Time Signatures · Rhythm Patterns
4	**Reading tunes**	Steps & Skips · Tempo Race
5	**Theory**	Intervals · Scales · Key Signatures · Chords
6	**Making music**	Melody & Phrasing · Musical Form · Dynamics & Articulation · Signs · Musical Terms
7	**Know the music**	The Piano's Story · Famous Composers · Pitch, Hz & Range · Styles & Genres

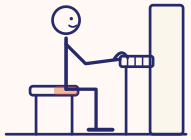
★ **All steps ticked?** Do the Chapter check-up on page 7 in your lesson, then colour in the badge.

Lesson step 1-3 Set _____ Due _____ 10 min · scan → step 1 online first · drill level ___ best ___/10

TOGETHER Is this good sitting?

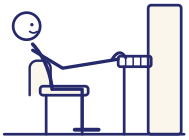
Look at each picture with your teacher and try it at the piano. Circle the tick or the cross.

EXAMPLE



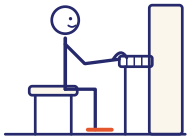
Front half of the chair ✓ ✗

2



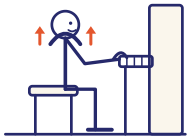
Leaning back, like on a sofa ✓ ✗

3



Feet flat on the floor ✓ ✗

4

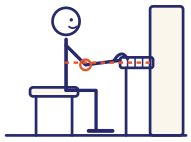


Shoulders up near the ears ✓ ✗

AT HOME Sitting and arms

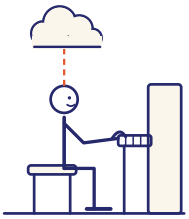
Try each one at home, then circle the tick or the cross.

1



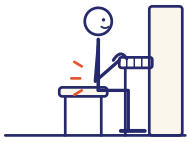
Elbows level with the keys ✓ ✗

2



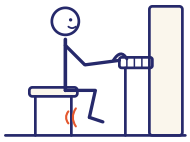
Sitting tall, like a puppet on a string ✓ ✗

3



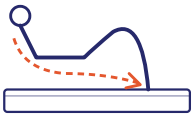
So close the elbows squash in ✓ ✗

4



Feet swinging in the air ✓ ✗

5



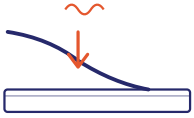
Playing from the whole arm ✓ ✗

6



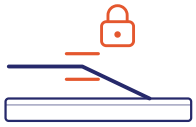
Squeezing hard to play loud ✓ ✗

7



A heavy arm, resting on the keys ✓ ✗

8



A wrist locked stiff ✓ ✗

★ PLAY Draw yourself at the piano

Draw yourself sitting at the piano -- tall back, feet flat, round hands. Then give yourself a star for each thing you got right!

☆ tall back
☆ feet flat
☆ elbows level
☆ round hands

How did it feel? Circle one. 🙂 😐 ☹ Teacher ☐

Lesson step 4-6 Set _____ Due _____ 10 min · scan → step 4 online first · drill level ___ best ___/10

TOGETHER Which finger?

Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on BOTH hands. Write the number of the coloured finger.



Round fingers, like holding a ball. The thumb lies on its side corner, like a boat tipped on its side.

EXAMPLE



3

2



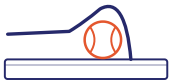
3



AT HOME Hand shape and fingers

Circle the tick or the cross for each hand. Then write the number of the coloured finger.

1



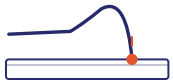
Round fingers, like holding a ball

2



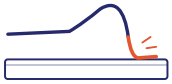
Flat, straight fingers

3



Playing on the tip of the finger

4



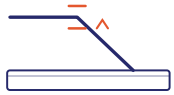
A finger tip that bends backwards

5



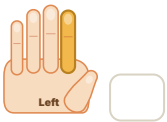
Thumb on its side corner, like a tipped boat

6



A stiff wrist, held up high

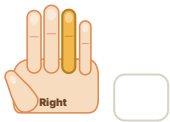
7



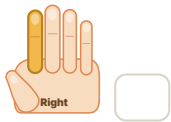
8



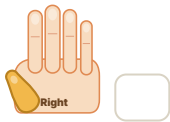
9



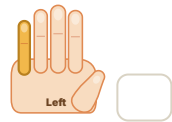
10



11



12



Lesson step 4-6 Set _____ Due _____ 5 min · scan → step 4 online first · drill level ___ best ___/10

★ PLAY Trace your hands

Put each hand flat in its box and draw round it. Write the finger numbers on every finger -- the thumb is 1 on both hands! Then draw a ring on each finger 4.

Left hand

Right hand

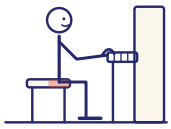
Check: ☐ 5 fingers on each hand ☐ Thumbs are 1 ☐ A ring round each finger 4

☐ Left and right the right way round

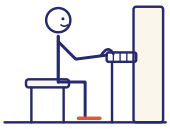
Lesson step 7 Set _____ Due _____ 5 min · scan → step 7 online first · drill level ___ best ___/10

TOGETHER My posture checklist

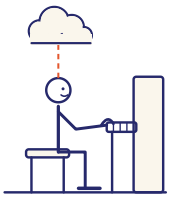
Your teacher checks each one at the piano. A tick for every one that's right today.



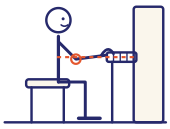
Front half of the chair ☐



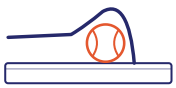
Feet flat ☐



Sitting tall ☐



Elbows level ☐



Round hands ☐

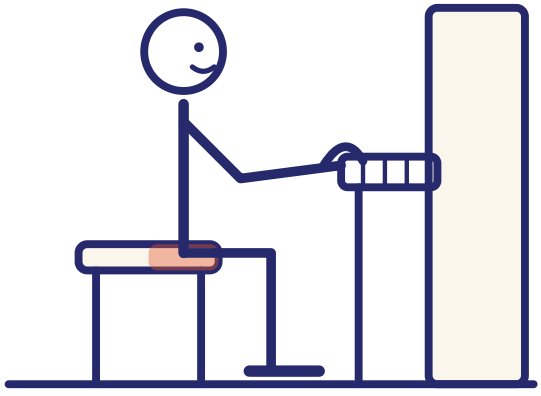
AT HOME Posture every day

Before you practise, check yourself in a mirror or ask someone at home. Tick each one you get right.

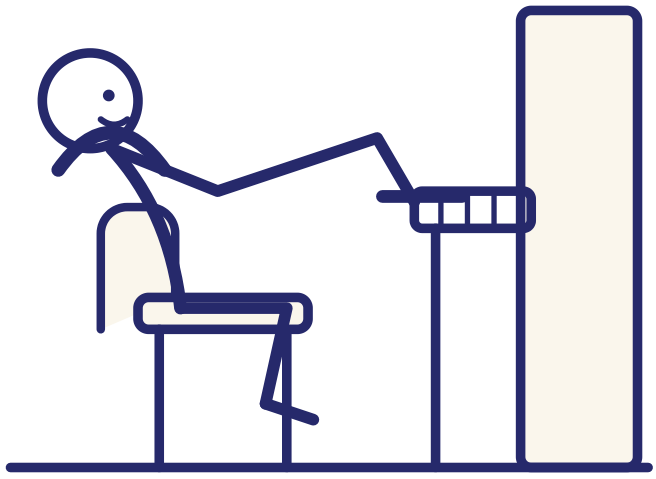
	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Front of the chair	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Feet flat	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sitting tall	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Elbows level	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Round hands	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Spot the difference

The kid on the left sits well. The kid on the right is doing 5 things wrong. Circle every mistake you can find, then colour a star for each one.



Good sitting



5 mistakes -- circle them

Found: ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

Chapter check-up

In the lesson -- no help, no piano -- about 10 minutes

Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 20

A Good sitting? Circle the tick or the cross.

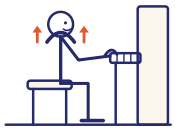
1



Feet swinging in the air

✓ ✗

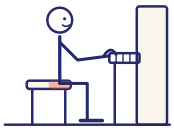
2



Shoulders up near the ears

✓ ✗

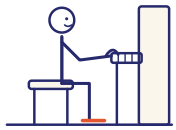
3



Front half of the chair

✓ ✗

4

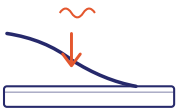


Feet flat on the floor

✓ ✗

B Arm weight: tick or cross?

5



A heavy arm, resting on the keys

✓ ✗

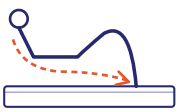
6



Squeezing hard to play loud

✓ ✗

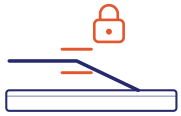
7



Playing from the whole arm

✓ ✗

8



A wrist locked stiff

✓ ✗

C Good hand shape? Circle the tick or the cross.

9



Flat, straight fingers

✓ ✗

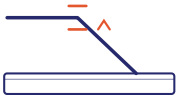
10



Thumb on its side corner, like a tipped boat

✓ ✗

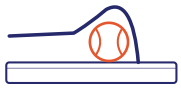
11



A stiff wrist, held up high

✓ ✗

12

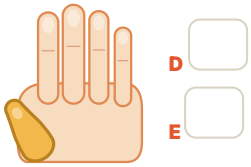


Round fingers, like holding a ball

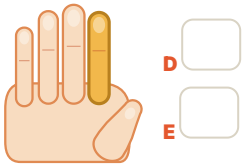
✓ ✗

D Left or right hand? Write L or R. E Which finger is coloured?

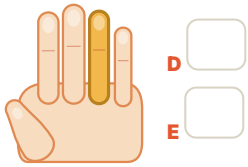
13 · 17



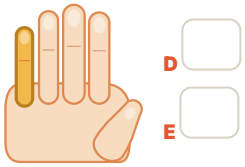
14 · 18



15 · 19



16 · 20



Concept	Score	Pass mark	Passed?
A Sitting at the piano	___ / 4	3+	☐
B Arm weight	___ / 4	3+	☐
C Hand shape	___ / 4	3+	☐
D Left hand, right hand	___ / 4	3+	☐
E Finger numbers	___ / 4	3+	☐

Chapter complete! Every concept passed? Colour in the badge and add your name to it.

Teacher copy · Posture & Hand Shape

Every answer here should also be tried at the piano -- the paper is only the reminder.

p. 3 Sitting and arm weight

TOGETHER 1. ✓ **tick** 2. × **cross** 3. ✓ **tick** 4. × **cross**

AT HOME 1. ✓ **tick** 2. ✓ **tick** 3. × **cross** 4. × **cross** 5. ✓ **tick** 6. × **cross** 7. ✓ **tick** 8. × **cross**

Watch for
Sitting too close (elbows squashed) or too far (leaning forward). Feet dangling -- a footstool fixes it.

If stuck, try saying
"Sit tall like a puppet on a string. Arms heavy like wet spaghetti, then rest them on the keys."

p. 4 Hand shape and fingers

TOGETHER 1. **3 (R)** 2. **1 (L)** 3. **5 (R)**

AT HOME 1. ✓ **tick** 2. × **cross** 3. ✓ **tick** 4. × **cross** 5. ✓ **tick** 6. × **cross** 7. **2 (L)** 8. **3 (L)** 9. **4 (R)** 10. **2 (R)** 11. **1 (R)** 12. **5 (L)**

Watch for
Numbering the left hand from the little finger. The thumb is 1 on both hands.

If stuck, try saying
"Thumbs are always 1 -- both hands are mirror twins."

p. 5 Trace your hands

Check: five fingers on each hand, the thumb numbered 1 on BOTH hands, a ring round each finger 4, and left and right the right way round.

Watch for
Numbering the left hand from the little finger -- the thumb is 1 on both hands. Fingers squeezed together or curled up: ask for a relaxed, slightly spread hand.

If stuck, try saying
"Hand flat like a starfish, pencil standing up, and draw slowly round the edge."

p. 6 Posture check

Tick only what you see today. Return to the weakest one first next lesson. PLAY: leaning back like a sofa, shoulders up by the ears, feet swinging, flat fingers, wrist held up high.

Watch for
Collapsing end joints, especially finger 5 -- play on the tip, not the pad.

If stuck, try saying
"Hold a little bubble in your hand -- don't pop it!"

p. 7 Check-up

A 1. **× cross** 2. **× cross** 3. **✓ tick** 4. **✓ tick**

B 1. **✓ tick** 2. **× cross** 3. **✓ tick** 4. **× cross**

C 1. **× cross** 2. **✓ tick** 3. **× cross** 4. **✓ tick**

D 1. **R** 2. **L** 3. **R** 4. **L**

E 1. **1** 2. **2** 3. **4** 4. **5**

Score each concept on its own (4 marks each, pass 3+). Then check posture at the piano, not just on paper.

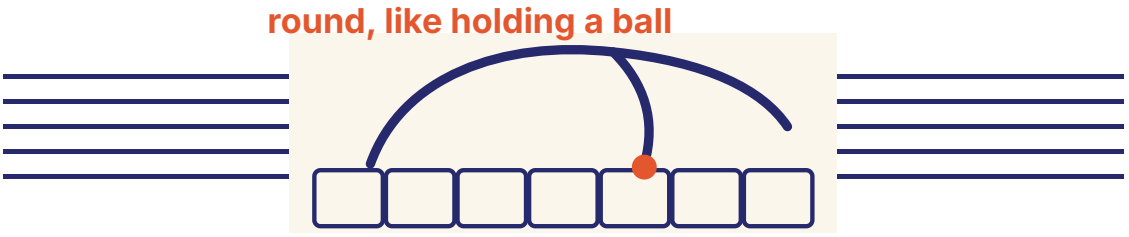
If a concept is not passed, go back to: **A** Lesson step 1, workbook page 3 · **B** Lesson step 2-3, workbook page 3 · **C** Lesson step 4, workbook page 4 · **D** Lesson step 5-6, workbook page 4 · **E** Lesson step 5-6, workbook page 4

Chapter 1 of 25 · Getting started

Posture and hand shape

Before the first note: how to sit, and how to hold the hand. Get these two right and everything after them gets easier, and kinder to the body.

DRAFT Written by Sohyun, a piano teacher in Sydney · Updated 8 October 2026

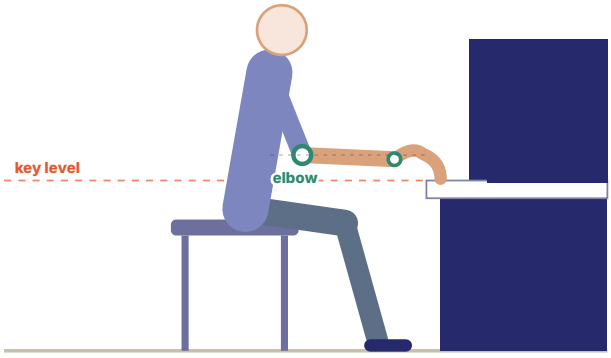


From the teacher

DRAFT [Your answer to question 1: what do students get wrong most in this chapter? Two or three sentences in your own words.]

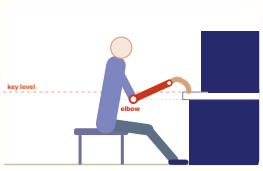
Set up the stool

Two things decide everything: how high the stool is, and how far it is from the keys. Fix those first, then sit tall, like a puppet on a string.

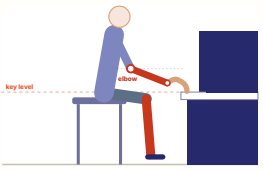


- **Height:** the forearm is level with the keys.
- **Distance:** the elbows sit just in front of the body, open a little to the side.
- **Front half of the stool,** feet flat on the floor, facing middle C.
- Feet don't reach? Put a footstool or a sturdy box under them.

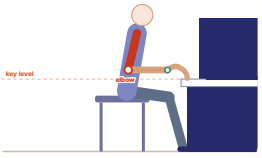
Four ways it goes wrong



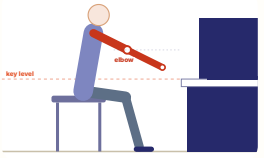
× Stool too low
The forearm slopes up to the keys and the shoulders hunch. **Raise the stool.**



× Stool too high
The forearm slopes down onto the keys. **Lower the stool** until the forearm is level.



× Too close
The elbows are squashed behind the body. **Slide the stool back** a little.



× Too far
The arms reach out ahead of the body. **Slide the stool closer.**

Let the arm carry the hand

Fingers press the keys, but the arm takes the hand where it needs to go. The hand keeps its shape the whole way. These six warm-ups take a few minutes at the start of practice.

1 Rag doll
Let both arms hang heavy, shake them loose from the shoulders, then float the hands up to the keys. Shoulders stay down.

2 Knuckle bridge
All five fingertips rest on C D E F G. Press one key slowly to the bottom and hold for three. The knuckles stay up.

3 Arm glide
Put the hand shape on middle C and carry it up to the next C, and the next. The fingers don't walk: the arm carries them.

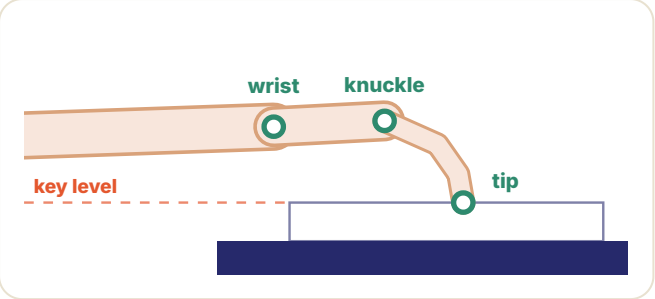
4 Elbow wings
Hands still on the keys, let the elbows float out to the side and back. Stop in the middle, about a fist from the body.

5 Wrist balloon
Imagine a balloon tied to the wrist. It lifts the wrist while the fingertip stays on the key, then the wrist floats back down to level.

6 Arm drop
Lift the whole arm, keep the hand shape, and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm fingertip, soft wrist, a full round sound.

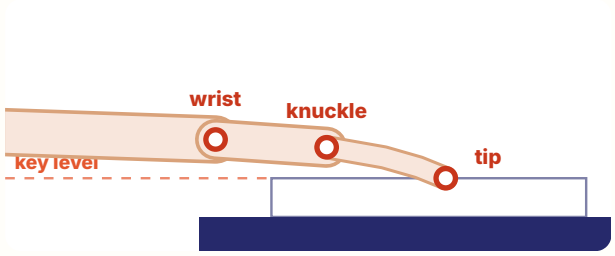
A round hand

Let the arms hang, then lift the hands as if holding a small ball. That round shape is the one to keep on the keys.



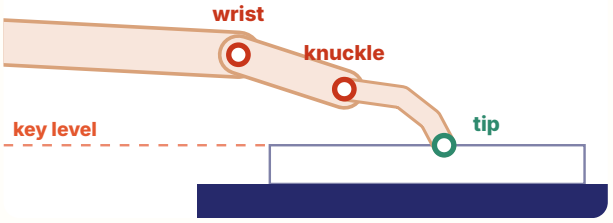
- **Knuckles up,** like a bridge. They are the highest point.
- **Wrist level** with the forearm, not dropped and not hunched.
- **Play on the fingertip pad,** with the fingers curved down.
- **The thumb plays on its side corner,** like a boat tipped on its side.

Five faults, and the fix for each



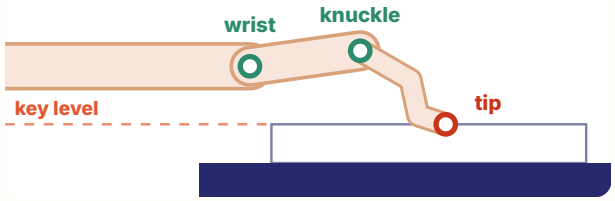
× Flat fingers

The key is played with the soft middle of the finger. **Fix:** hold a small ball, or a mandarin, and put that round shape on the keys.



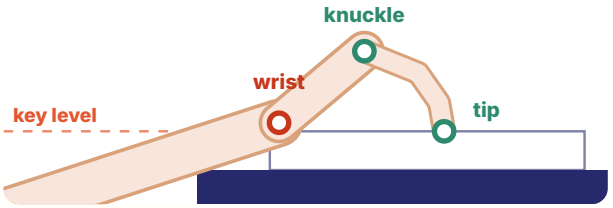
× Knuckles collapsed

The bridge has fallen in, lower than the wrist. **Fix:** the knuckle bridge warm-up, with the knuckles staying up.



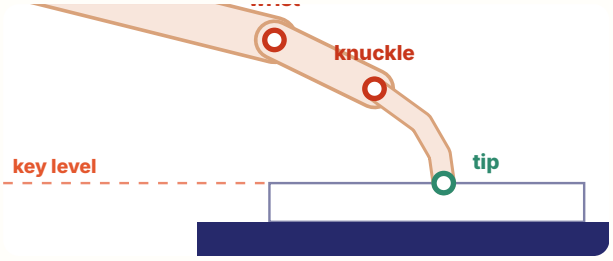
× Tip joint caving in

The last joint bends backwards as the finger plays. **Fix:** play slowly on the tip, press down and hold. The tip stays firm, like a little pillar.



× Wrist dropped

The wrist sinks below the keys and the hand has to push up. **Fix:** the wrist balloon, floating up to level.



× Wrist too high

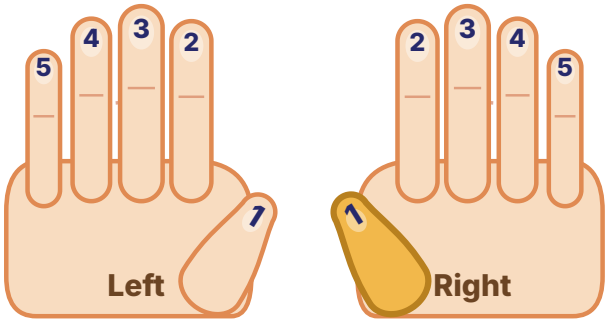
The wrist hunches up and the fingers poke straight down. **Fix:** let it sink until elbow, wrist and knuckle make a straight line.

Teacher's tip

DRAFT [Your answer to question 2: what do you say or do that works? For example the teacher copy now says: "Hold a little bubble in your hand, don't pop it!"]

Finger numbers

Every finger has a number, 1 to 5, starting from the thumb. It's the same on both hands, so both thumbs are 1 and both little fingers are 5. Teachers say "put finger 2 on D" all the time, so the numbers need to be automatic before reading fingering on the page.



1 Captain Thumb | 2 Pointer | 3 Tall Middle | 4 Shy Ring | 5 Baby Pinky

A quick game: hold both hands up, wiggle each finger as you say its number, then call out "Show me left hand, finger 3!" and swap.

A quick posture check

The same check every time, so you can see it improve. Print this page, or just run through it before practice.

Sitting

- [ ] Stool height: forearm level with the keys
- [ ] Distance: elbows just in front of the body
- [ ] Sitting on the front half of the stool
- [ ] Feet flat (or on a footstool)
- [ ] Back tall, leaning slightly forward
- [ ] Shoulders down and loose

Arms

- [ ] Elbows open, a fist's width from the body
- [ ] Forearm level, not sloping up or down
- [ ] Wrist level with the forearm

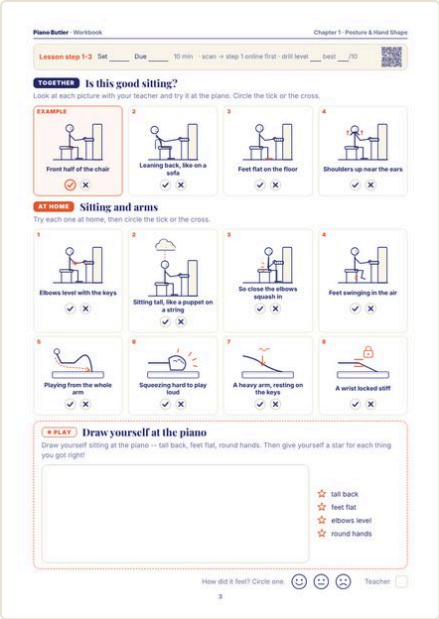
Hands

- [ ] Knuckles up, like a bridge
- [ ] Fingers curved, holding a ball
- [ ] Playing on the fingertip pads
- [ ] Tip joint firm, not caving in
- [ ] Thumb plays on its side corner

Moving

- [ ] The arm carries the hand along the keys
- [ ] The hand keeps its shape while moving
- [ ] No tension: the arm could wobble freely

Free worksheet



Is this good sitting?

Tick or cross eight pictures of sitting and arms, then draw yourself at the piano and give yourself a star for each thing you got right. One A4 page.

Common questions

How high should a piano stool be for a child?

High enough that the forearm is level with the keys. If the feet then don't reach the floor, put a footstool or a sturdy box under them rather than lowering the stool.

Should the wrist be high or low?

Neither: level with the forearm. A dropped wrist makes the hand push up; a high wrist makes the fingers poke straight down.

How far from the piano should you sit?

Close enough that the elbows sit just in front of the body, open a little to the side. Squashed elbows mean too close; arms reaching out mean too far.

Next chapter

2 · Black Keys & Your First Song

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